

Q6) To what extent is education a solution to the problem of discrimination?

Strengths	Weaknesses
There were very few good scripts. Scripts that did manage to pass well showed good conceptual understanding of discrimination and its causes, and managed to successfully differentiate it from inequality. Better scripts showed good knowledge of education in other societies and managed to avoid restricting the argument to Singapore.	Focusing on (income) inequality VS question's focus on discrimination Many scripts focused on how education could be used to improve social mobility/status instead of focusing on how education addresses the problem of prejudiced mindsets which lead to discriminatory behaviour. This is likely the result of blind memorising of the NSP's outline on how education overcomes social divide. This could have been overcome if scripts had just taken an extra step and drawn a clear link between inequality and discrimination e.g. (1) how educational empowerment of marginalised groups (women for e.g.) has given them greater capabilities and changed society's prejudiced views which resulted in fairer treatment for certain groups or (2) how erasing discriminatory attitudes has thus led to greater equality. Confusing meritocracy with education Students seem to think meritocracy and education are one and the same but they are not! Meritocracy is just a system/principle in which advancement/ success is a result of abilities (merit), not money or position or racial/gender advantage. However, meritocratic principles can be applied in education, but they should not be confused as one and the same. The confusion has led to students arguing for why meritocracy is seen as a solution to the problem of discrimination when in fact it exacerbates discrimination with educational elitism being a result of meritocracy. Hijacking the question (1) Ignoring the focus on the subject matter - education - and its effectiveness as a solution Problematic answers interpreted the question as - <i>Can the problem of discrimination ever be eliminated</i> - and ignored the focus on the evaluation of the effectiveness of education as a measure.

	(2) Problematic answers also treated the question as - <i>Is education the <u>only</u> solution to the problem of discrimination</i> - and proceeded to list other solutions apart from education.
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Key words

education: It does not refer solely to formal education (the teaching and learning of knowledge and skills in schools/institutions) but also informal education (raising awareness of discrimination/prejudicial treatment through public campaigns)

solution: a means of solving a problem or dealing with a difficult situation

discrimination: the unjust or prejudicial treatment of different categories of people, especially on the grounds of race, age, sex, or socio-economic class.

Cause of discrimination: At the heart of all forms of discrimination is prejudice based on concepts of identity, and the need to identify with a certain group. This can lead to scapegoating, hatred and even the dehumanization of other people because they have a different identity, which is further aggravated by the politics of blame and fear.

Some key forms of discrimination:

- Racial and ethnic discrimination
- Discrimination against non-nationals, sometimes known as xenophobia
- Discrimination against LGBTI people
- Gender discrimination
- Caste discrimination
- Discrimination against those with disabilities
- Class-based discrimination or classism

Approach

- a. Explain why education is perceived as a solution to discrimination
- b. Identify the limitations of education which render it ineffective in addressing the problem of discrimination fully

a. Reasons why education is perceived as a solution to discrimination

- Education plays an important role in **changing mindsets by debunking stereotypes** which are formed or fuelled by prejudice that can lead to discriminatory acts.
 - Stereotypes usually form due to ignorance/misconceptions, e.g. associating terrorism with Muslims/Arabs or Blacks with criminal tendencies, which often leads to discriminatory behaviour against these groups of people.
 - Passing on objective and/or new information (about certain groups), whether in the form of formal education or public campaigns, deconstructs prejudicial narratives and broadens people's perspectives. When people are exposed to new (and convincing) information that challenges their usual way of thinking, it could also change the way they behave towards a specific group of people.

- E.g. This is evident in campaigns championing the rights of the disabled – they would demonstrate the capabilities and talents of the handicapped in a bid to change society's perception, particularly that of employers, of them being useless and unable to integrate into the work force.
- Education helps to **promote important values that prevent/alleviate discrimination**. Social interaction in most formal education settings also **increases empathy** for those who are different.
 - Schools often emphasise compassion, empathy, equality and inclusivity in their curriculum, important values that help develop understanding and respect for other groups who are different.
 - E.g. Mission Hill School and Move this World are just some of the schools and programmes that educate children and teens in understanding and embracing differences. Cooperative learning practised in many schools today also give students opportunities to work with people of different backgrounds and reduces social divisions.

b. Limitations of education which render it ineffective in addressing the problem of discrimination fully

- Sometimes, the **prejudice is too deep-seated for any form of education to effect changes**.
 - Biases are developed during the formative years as a result of influences from family and friends, the government, the media, religion, and even schools, or limited personal experiences which may not be representative of those of the vast majority. But once these biases are internalised, they are extremely difficult to change.
 - People would generally pay attention to information that reinforces stereotypes and avoid information that points to the contrary. Even when confronted by facts that debunk misconceptions of a particular social group, people may try to discount its validity in order to reduce cognitive dissonance (mental discomfort arising from holding conflicting views and beliefs).
 - E.g. In spite of the gay rights movement and its public campaigns making great strides in the United States (the chief of which being the legalisation of same-sex marriage in the country), prejudice against the LGBT community is still strong, particularly among the conservatives. For example, in July 2017, President Trump dropped a bombshell on Twitter announcing that the United States government would not accept or allow transgender individuals to serve in any capacity in the U.S. military. The reason being the military could not afford to be burdened by the tremendous medical costs and disruption that having transgender people in the military could entail. It was widely condemned as a homophobic move, vilifying the transgender people in the public's eye, even though an earlier Pentagon-commissioned study concluded that there were no reasons to exclude transgender individuals from military service.
- Education may end up **worsening discrimination** instead.
 - While ideally, social interaction in schools is supposed to increase empathy and promote inclusivity, in reality, education often results in **greater segregation** and exacerbates discrimination instead.

Elitism and discrimination

- Education may end up worsening elitism when there is a lack of interaction with students of other social classes. This segregation is brought about by two possible factors:
 1. *Unequal schools* – elite/private schools in other countries disproportionately attract students from privileged, well-to-do family backgrounds who can afford expensive tuition fees. Students attending these schools enjoy advantages and enrichment opportunities that poorer students do not have access to, and end up doing better in life as well.

** Singapore should not be cited as an example here, as there are many financial assistance schemes that help less privileged students cope with the cost of education even in independent/autonomous schools.*

2. *Educational meritocracy* – Segregation of students by academic abilities occurs in many societies e.g. educational sorting often begins very early in the United States, when schoolchildren are selected for “gifted and talented” programs, and it continues in high school, where some students are pushed onto vocational tracks. However, students who come from privileged backgrounds tend to do better in school due to access to more educational resources and are often segregated into better schools and classes. This separates them from the poorer or middle-income students who might not have access to the same privileges as they did and perform as well.
- What such segregation ends up doing is contribute to an elitist mindset where students who performed well or entered elite schools have attitudes such as “I got into a good school because I am hardworking and smart and others did not because they were lazy” or that “I am superior because I come from an elite school”. Such mindsets often translate to discriminatory behaviour against those who do not come from an elite school background or who do not make the cut academically.
 - In Singapore, students from lower-income families tend to have poorer educational outcomes and instances of Express stream students, or even teachers, ostracising and making condescending remarks about Normal stream students being “stupid” or “slow learners” are not uncommon.

<https://www.channelnewsasia.com/news/singapore/the-big-read-streaming-the-good-the-bad-and-the-ugly-side-of-an-11332116>

Other forms of discrimination e.g. against LGBTs

- Education does not always change mindsets but **reinforces biases**, making the elimination of discrimination even more difficult.
- Some schools may perpetuate vile stereotypes and influence young impressionable minds who may go on to discriminate against those who are maligned. These biases and prejudices are even institutionalised in the school rules or perpetuated through the curriculum.
- This is evidenced by some schools in the United States prohibiting their students from bringing same-sex dates to prom.